

Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion — Specifications

Specifications

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Release: 2026.07

Identity framework, blueprint, design principles, notation standards

0.1 Manual volumes in this release

PDF	Description
00-Trainers-Manual.pdf	Field teaching handbook for instructors and pilot collaborators
01-Specifications.pdf	Identity framework, blueprint, design principles, notation standards
02-Reference.pdf	Concept library, technique, grids, sound model
03-User-Guides.pdf	Instructor, pilot, arranging, and educational guidance
04-Research.pdf	Indigenous percussion, Kaamulan, marching heritage

PDF	Description
05-Architecture.pdf	Documentation architecture and ADRs
06-Governance.pdf	EDF governance, metadata, change management
07-AI-Development.pdf	AI-assisted workflow and project development notes
08-Templates-and-Placeholders.pdf	Templates and inactive EDF domain placeholders

1 Specifications

This domain contains authoritative statements of project intent, constraints, required behavior, and design standards.

1.1 Contents

- [Philippine Marching Percussion Identity Framework](#) — musical constitution and identity
- [Core Blueprint](#) — operational implementation and roadmap
- [Design Principles](#) — how identity influences practice
- [Notation Standards](#) — notation conventions (in development)

2 Philippine Marching Percussion Identity Framework

Status: Maintained **Owner:** Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion Project **Applies To:** All musical, educational, arranging, and performance decisions **Last Reviewed:** 2026-07-13 **Review Frequency:** Quarterly **Authoritative:** Yes

2.1 Purpose

This document is the project’s musical constitution. It defines the identity of the Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion style rather than teaching performance techniques.

Every major composition, educational exercise, arrangement, rehearsal concept, and technical innovation should be evaluated against this framework before it is adopted.

2.2 Vision

The Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion Project is intended to establish a **new, distinctly Filipino modern marching percussion tradition**.

The objective is **not** to imitate Drum Corps International (DCI), Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCU), military drum corps, or any other foreign tradition.

Instead, the project preserves and elevates Philippine musical identity by combining:

- [Indigenous Philippine musical traditions](#)
- [Philippine community and festival percussion \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [Modern Philippine Drum & Lyre traditions \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [Modern educational methods](#)
- Carefully selected DCI techniques
- Carefully selected HBCU showmanship

The guiding philosophy is:

Modernization without imitation.

2.3 Identity Statement

The Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion style is unmistakably Filipino. It preserves the energy, groove, community character, and cultural roots of Philippine percussion while adopting modern technique, notation, pedagogy, and ensemble sophistication only where those tools strengthen—not replace—Philippine identity.

Future audiences should recognize the sound as distinctly Filipino not because international influences are rejected, but because every adopted idea has been thoughtfully adapted to reinforce Philippine musical identity.

2.4 Primary Design Filter

Every design decision should answer:

“Does this preserve Philippine identity while improving musicianship?”

This question is the central filter for the entire project.

2.5 Guiding Principles

2.5.1 Philippine Identity First

Philippine cultural roots are the foundation. Higher layers of technique, arrangement, and visual design must never replace lower layers of cultural identity.

See also [Design Principles — Primary Filter \(Trainers Manual\)](#).

2.5.2 Modernization Without Imitation

The project modernizes Philippine percussion. It does not copy foreign traditions as identity substitutes.

See also [Modernization Without Imitation \(Trainers Manual\)](#).

2.5.3 Educational Excellence

Technique, literacy, and progressive pedagogy serve musicianship and teachability in Philippine school and community contexts.

See also [Design Principles — Educational Philosophy \(Trainers Manual\)](#).

2.5.4 Accessibility

Materials must remain practical for local instrumentation, reading levels, and rehearsal environments.

See also [Instructor Introduction](#).

2.5.5 Community

Performance energy, audience participation, and ensemble communication reflect Philippine community and festival traditions.

See also [Community Performance Traditions \(Trainers Manual\)](#).

2.5.6 Performance Excellence

Technical sophistication and showmanship are welcome when they strengthen identity rather than obscure it.

See also [Design Principles — Performance Philosophy \(Trainers Manual\)](#).

2.6 Historical Foundation

The style evolves through the following lineage:

Indigenous Philippine Traditions
↓
Community and Festival Music
↓
Military and Drum & Lyre Heritage
↓
Modern Philippine Marching Performance
↓
Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion

Lineage references:

- [Indigenous Philippine Traditions](#)
- [Community and Festival Music](#)
- [Military and Drum & Lyre Heritage \(Research\)](#)
- [Modern Philippine Marching Performance \(Research\)](#)
- [Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion](#)

2.7 Indigenous Philippine Foundations

Indigenous musical traditions are the deepest cultural roots of the project.

Important concepts include:

- [layered rhythmic structures \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [call-and-response \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [community participation \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [music integrated with movement \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [rhythmic endurance \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [ceremonial performance \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [regional diversity \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [collective groove \(Trainers Manual\)](#)

The project respectfully adapts these ideas rather than attempting literal recreation.

See also [Indigenous Philippine Percussion](#) and the [Concept Library](#).

2.8 Community and Festival Traditions

Philippine festivals influence:

- performance energy (Trainers Manual)
- movement (Trainers Manual)
- ensemble interaction (Trainers Manual)
- audience participation (Trainers Manual)
- celebration through percussion (Trainers Manual)

See also [Kaamulan Festival](#).

2.9 Kaamulan Festival

The Kaamulan Festival is one of the project's primary cultural reference points.

Research topics include:

- rhythmic layering (Trainers Manual)
- movement (Trainers Manual)
- audience interaction (Trainers Manual)
- ceremonial pacing (Trainers Manual)
- community participation (Trainers Manual)
- visual-musical integration (Trainers Manual)

Kaamulan is treated as inspiration rather than something to copy directly.

2.10 Drum & Lyre Heritage

Preserve:

- recognizable Philippine grooves (Trainers Manual)
- energetic performance (Trainers Manual)
- educational accessibility (Trainers Manual)
- audience connection (Trainers Manual)

Improve:

- technique
- pedagogy
- arranging
- notation
- rehearsal methods (Trainers Manual)
- ensemble balance (Reference)

2.11 International Influences

International traditions are educational resources rather than identities.

Tradition	Relationship
Philippine Drum & Lyre (Trainers Manual)	Preserve
Philippine Festival Traditions (Trainers Manual)	Preserve

Tradition	Relationship
Indigenous Philippine Music	Preserve
DCI	Adapt
HBCU	Adapt
Military Drum Corps (Research)	Selectively adapt
Other traditions	Evaluate individually

2.12 Translate Musical Ideas—Not Instruments

Rather than imitating indigenous instruments, modern battery writing translates:

- groove (Reference)
- phrasing (Reference)
- rhythmic interaction (Trainers Manual)
- ensemble communication (Trainers Manual)
- expressive dynamics (Reference)
- musical energy (Trainers Manual)

into contemporary marching percussion.

2.13 Indigenous Percussion Performance Practices

The project studies and adapts concepts from indigenous Philippine hand-drumming traditions, including:

- open tone concepts (Trainers Manual)
- muted articulations (Trainers Manual)
- accented gestures (Trainers Manual)
- interlocking rhythms (Trainers Manual)
- ensemble communication (Trainers Manual)
- body movement (Trainers Manual)
- rhythmic dialogue (Trainers Manual)
- performance energy (Trainers Manual)

Many of these concepts also appear in other hand-drum traditions (such as djembe performance practice). The project’s cultural foundation remains Philippine.

2.14 Identity Layers

Philippine Cultural Identity

↓

Rhythmic Language

↓

Educational Philosophy

↓

Modern Battery Technique

↓

Visual Performance

↓

Performance Excellence

Higher layers should never replace lower layers.

2.15 Modernization Strategy

When evaluating new ideas, contributors should ask:

“How would this sound if it had originated in the Philippines?”

rather than:

“Can we make this sound like DCI?”

2.16 Future Evolution

The style should continue evolving while remaining unmistakably Filipino.

Innovation is encouraged when it strengthens the project’s identity.

2.17 Related Documents

- [Instructor Introduction](#) — educator entry point
- [Design Principles](#) — how identity influences practice
- [Core Blueprint](#) — operational implementation and roadmap
- [Concept Library](#) — reusable concept definitions
- [Philippine Percussion Sound Model](#)
- [Philippine Marching Heritage](#) — historical lineage research
- [Indigenous Philippine Percussion](#)
- [Kaamulan Festival](#)
- [Arranging Guide](#)
- [Educational Handbook](#)

2.18 Appendix: Identity Preservation Checklist

Every major composition, educational exercise, arrangement, rehearsal concept, or technical innovation should be evaluated against:

- Does this preserve Philippine identity?
- Does it strengthen existing Philippine traditions?
- Is it culturally respectful?
- Does it improve musicianship?
- Is it practical for Philippine schools?
- Does it encourage creativity?
- Does it remain educationally sustainable?
- Are international influences supporting rather than dominating the music?
- Does the resulting performance still sound unmistakably Filipino?

3 Blueprint Plan: The Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion

Status: Maintained **Owner:** Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion Project **Applies To:** Implementation, platform, pedagogy, and roadmap **Last Reviewed:** 2026-07-13
Review Frequency: Quarterly **Authoritative:** Yes

3.1 Relationship to the Identity Framework

This document is the **operational blueprint**—platform, pedagogy, arranging method, and implementation roadmap.

The **Philippine Marching Percussion Identity Framework** is the project’s **musical constitution**. It defines identity, cultural foundations, and the Identity Preservation Checklist. Consult it before applying the methods described here.

3.2 1. Project Overview

The Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion Project modernizes traditional Philippine Drum & Lyre and festival street drumming by combining the best elements of three musical traditions into a uniquely Filipino performance style.

Rather than copying American drumlines, the objective is to preserve the powerful energy and cultural character of local street drumming while incorporating the technical sophistication of modern marching percussion.

The guiding philosophy is **modernization without imitation**. See the **Identity Framework**.

The project blends:

- **Traditional Philippine festival drumming:** raw energy, native syncopation, bass-drum momentum, audience participation, and cultural identity.
- **Drum Corps International (DCI):** rudimental precision, advanced battery writing, modern tenor movement, dynamic phrasing, and formal notation.
- **Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCU):** showmanship, swagger or *ya-bang*, hip-hop-influenced grooves, crowd engagement, and visual entertainment.

3.3 2. Technology Platform

The primary production environment is:

- MuseScore Studio 4
- Muse Hub
- Muse Drumline (MDL2), recorded by the Blue Devils
- Apple Silicon Mac mini

Muse Drumline playback is used as a validation aid to test clarity, timing, splits, orchestration, and balance before material is introduced to performers.

3.4 3. Pedagogy: From Rote Learning to Blended Literacy

Traditional local lines often learn primarily by ear. This develops listening, memory, feel, and cultural continuity, but may limit repeatability, preservation, and advanced rhythmic organization.

The project introduces notation as an additional tool rather than a replacement for learning by ear.

3.4.1 Hybrid Warm-Up System

Technical exercises will combine marching-percussion fundamentals with Philippine rhythmic vocabulary.

Initial subjects include:

- **legatos**;
- double strokes;
- **accent-taps**;
- **8-8-16**;
- flams;
- **grid exercises**.

DCI stick-height control and sound-quality expectations will be taught through accent groupings influenced by Philippine festival rhythms.

3.5 4. Three-Layer Arranging Method

3.5.1 Layer A — The Soul

Preserve the recognizable pulse and syncopation of Philippine festival drumming.

Bass drums

- driving heartbeat;
- native syncopation;
- dance-oriented momentum.

Cymbals

- reinforce pulse;
- increase energy;
- support visual and crowd impact.

3.5.2 Layer B — The Precision

Apply modern drum-corps vocabulary over the native groove.

Snares

Potential vocabulary includes hertas, paradiddle-diddles, cheese flams, tap drags, grids, and inverted rudiments.

Tenors

Potential vocabulary includes sweeps, scrapes, multi-tonal movement, and split orchestration.

When only single sling tenors are available, differently pitched drums may be distributed among players so the line functions collectively as a multi-tonal instrument.

3.5.3 Layer C — The Contrast

Use HBCU- and contemporary-influenced contrast through:

- halftime grooves;
- hip-hop-influenced breakdowns;
- triplets;
- metric shifts;
- explosive returns to festival tempo.

3.6 5. Visual Identity: Philippine Yabang

The visual program should be confidently Filipino rather than an imitation of another tradition.

Possible influences include:

- Tinikling-inspired weight shifts;
- indigenous or regional warrior stances;
- folk-dance movement;
- festival choreography;
- back-sticking;
- side flashes;
- overhead stick visuals;
- crowd interaction.

3.7 6. Implementation Roadmap

3.7.1 Phase 1 — Foundation

- Establish the EDF-compatible project structure.
- Configure MuseScore Studio 4 and Muse Drumline.
- Define notation and playback standards.
- Create the initial hybrid warm-up package.

3.7.2 Phase 2 — Proof of Concept

Compose a 16-bar hybrid cadence demonstrating:

- native bass-drum groove;
- DCI-inspired snare writing;
- modern tenor orchestration;
- HBCU-inspired contrast;
- a strong ensemble conclusion.

3.7.3 Phase 3 — Pilot Instruction

Introduce the written material to a local pilot group using blended listening, imitation, notation, and sectional practice tracks.

3.7.4 Phase 4 — Refinement and Expansion

Evaluate reading development, technical improvement, cultural authenticity, audience response, teachability, and instrumentation constraints.

3.8 7. Guiding Design Principles

These operational principles align with the [Design Principles](#) and [Identity Framework](#):

1. Preserve the soul of Philippine street drumming.
2. Technique must support musicality.
3. Complexity must remain teachable.
4. Visual design must reinforce the music.

5. Local instrumentation should be treated creatively rather than as a deficiency.
6. Cultural identity takes priority over imitation.
7. The system should be reusable and expandable by future educators.

3.9 Related Documents

- [Philippine Marching Percussion Identity Framework](#)
- [Design Principles](#)
- [Arranging Guide](#)
- [Educational Handbook](#)

4 Design Principles

Status: Maintained **Owner:** Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion Project **Applies To:** Arranging, education, rehearsal, performance, and governance decisions **Last Reviewed:** 2026-07-13 **Review Frequency:** Quarterly **Authoritative:** Yes

4.1 Purpose

This document explains how the [Philippine Marching Percussion Identity Framework](#) influences practical project work. It references the Identity Framework rather than duplicating it.

4.2 Primary Filter

All design work should answer:

“Does this preserve Philippine identity while improving musicianship?”

4.3 Educational Philosophy

Identity influences pedagogy by requiring:

- cultural understanding alongside technical development
- groove before speed
- movement integrated with music
- study of indigenous and festival traditions as context, not decoration
- progressive student development suited to Philippine school environments
- blended ear-and-notation literacy without replacing oral tradition

See [Educational Handbook](#).

New educators and pilot instructors should begin with the [Instructor Introduction](#).

4.4 Technical Development

Technique serves musicality and identity:

- fundamentals are taught through Philippine rhythmic vocabulary where possible
- DCI stick-height and sound-quality expectations support—not replace—native groove
- complexity is introduced progressively and must remain teachable
- local instrumentation is treated creatively rather than as a deficiency

4.5 Arranging Philosophy

Arranging applies identity through:

- translating indigenous rhythms into battery writing
- layering traditional grooves as the foundation (Layer A — the soul)
- applying modern precision above native pulse (Layer B — the precision)
- using contrast and showmanship selectively (Layer C — the contrast)
- bass-drum philosophy rooted in festival momentum
- translating hand-drum articulation into battery textures
- preserving Philippine rhythmic identity while increasing musical sophistication

See [Arranging Guide](#) and [Core Blueprint](#).

4.6 Rehearsal Methodology

Rehearsal should reinforce:

- ensemble communication and call-and-response habits
- movement integrated with musical phrasing
- audience connection and performance energy
- sectional balance appropriate to available instrumentation
- identity evaluation using the [Identity Preservation Checklist \(Trainers Manual\)](#)

4.7 Performance Philosophy

Performance should be confidently Filipino rather than an imitation of another tradition.

Visual design, showmanship, and crowd engagement should reinforce music rooted in Philippine festival and community traditions.

4.8 Decision-Making

When evaluating new ideas:

1. Consult the Identity Framework and this document.
2. Apply the Identity Preservation Checklist.
3. Ask: “How would this sound if it had originated in the Philippines?”
4. Prefer strengthening Philippine traditions over adopting foreign identity.

4.9 Long-Term Governance

Major identity decisions, accepted exceptions, and evolution of the style should be recorded in:

- [Architecture Decision Records](#)
- [Project Journal](#)
- [Project Governance](#)

4.10 Related Documents

- [Philippine Marching Percussion Identity Framework](#)
- [Core Blueprint](#)
- [Concept Library](#)

5 Notation Standards

Status: Draft **Owner:** Philippine Marching Percussion Fusion Project **Applies To:** All scored musical deliverables in **scores/** **Last Reviewed:** 2026-07-13 **Review Frequency:** Quarterly **Authoritative:** Yes

5.1 Purpose

This document defines notation-related conventions only. Musical identity and arranging philosophy belong in the [Identity Framework](#) and [Arranging Guide](#).

5.2 Scope

This standard will contain:

- notation conventions for battery, cymbals, and auxiliary voices
- stick-height notation
- dynamics and articulation symbols
- rehearsal marks and player assignments
- split and voice-leading notation for tenors and multi-performer figures
- file naming conventions for MuseScore projects and exports
- MuseScore Studio 4 conventions (MDL2, staff layout, playback settings)
- export standards (PDF, audio, practice-track naming)

5.3 Indigenous-Inspired Articulations

If new notation is developed for indigenous-inspired articulations translated into battery writing, it belongs here—not in the Identity Framework or Concept Library.

5.4 Platform

MuseScore Studio 4 with Muse Drumline (MDL2) is the canonical notation platform for the initial stage. See [Core Blueprint](#).

5.5 Related Documents

- [Concept Library — Marching Percussion Notation Strategy \(Trainers Manual\)](#)
- [Arranging Guide](#)
- [Scores](#)

5.6 Status

Detailed notation rules are pending development. Initial conventions will be established during Phase 1 of the [Core Blueprint](#) implementation roadmap.